

Convalescent Snakes & Ladders — Mechanics of Game Play

This document explains the **mechanics** of the board: how movement, visibility, and interactions function during play.

1. Movement Rules

- The player moves **one square at a time**.
 - Forward movements use the 'Spacebar', or '↑' or '→' keys
 - Backward movements use the '↓' or '←' keys
 - You cannot jump freely around the board or choose destinations.
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2. The Tether (Return Mechanism)

The player is visually tethered to the starting (hospital) square.

- At any point, there is a small chance of being pulled back to the start for a 'clinic visit'.
 - If this happens, the player is briefly given the option to "recall" (press 'R' key) and return to where they were.
 - This mechanism is intentionally unpredictable but not punitive.
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3. Legibility

Only a limited portion of the board is legible at any time.

By default:

- Text on most squares is scrambled by a substitution cipher.
 - The current square plus the subsequent one are readable ie unscrambled.
 - A small number of recently visited squares remain readable. Squares in the 'distant past' (ie more than 6 moves ago) are re-scrambled.
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4. Text and Icon Behaviour

Squares may contain:

- Text only
- Icon only
- Text Over Icon (these behave like text-only squares)

If a square has an icon:

- The icon draws first and is visible until you land on the square.
- After a short pause, text is revealed.
- When you leave the square, the icon returns.

Pop-up squares:

- Pop-up squares have a speech bubble icon 'baked-in'
 - Initially these show a "call" – a possible clinician statement.
 - When you land the square it temporarily replace the initial "call" text with a "response".
 - This initial text re-appears when you move away.
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5. Spinner / Jump Squares

Some squares trigger a spinner (snake or ladder) event.

- These squares are unknown until you land on them.
 - On landing, a visual 'snakes and ladders' icon appears.
 - On the next movement input, the player is directed to a different square.
 - The destination is randomly selected from a pre-defined set, which represents either a tiny move forward, or a larger move backwards or forwards.
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6. Magnifier Mode

The web page is not sizeable (e.g Ctrl +/-) – this is a deliberate constraint.

To make squares more legible, a magnifier option (press 'M' key) will open a pop up window with large text on a white background.

The board is not optimised for play on a mobile phone.

6. Help Page

A Help window with movement instructions and useful keys can be opened by using the '?' key.

7. The "Cheat" Mode

Typing the word **cheat** toggles a special mode:

- All squares become legible.
- All icons are hidden.
- Spinner mechanics are disabled.
- Movement remains constrained to one square at a time.

This mode exists to allow study, review, or demonstration, not to "win" the game.

8. Why It Works This Way

The system is designed as an experiential model of what recovery feels like from the inside.

Mechanisms are in place to enforce:

- Partial knowledge
- Interrupted progress
- Uncertainty about future states
- The difference between *movement* and *improvement*

These mechanics are not obstacles — they are the teaching device.
